

PUPIL NAME: _____

CLASS: _____

MEDIEVAL ENGLAND & THE STRUGGLE FOR POWER

Crown, Church, Barons & Peasants: From Hastings to Bosworth (1066–1485)

OVERARCHING HISTORICAL ENQUIRY

“How far did power shift between King, Church, Lords, and Peasants?”



Primary Visual Source: *The Bayeux Tapestry (c. 1070s): Norman Cavalry Charging the Anglo-Saxon Shield Wall*

Commissioned by Bishop Odo of Bayeux

CURRICULUM SYNOPSIS • THE CRUCIBLE OF MEDIEVAL AUTHORITY

From the bloody ridge of Senlac Hill in 1066 to the muddy field of Bosworth in 1485, medieval England was defined by a ceaseless struggle for power. Norman conquerors built towering stone keeps and compiled the Domesday survey to subjugate a defeated realm; holy archbishops clashed with iron-willed monarchs over God's law; rebellious barons forced an extortionate king to seal Magna Carta; and when the Black Death wiped out nearly half the kingdom, ordinary peasants rose in armed revolt to demand an end to serfdom.

THE 9 DISCIPLINARY ENQUIRIES:

L1: 1066 & The Battle of Hastings

L6: 1348: The Black Death Crisis

L2: Castles, Terror & Domesday

L7: 1381: The Peasants' Revolt

L3: Crown vs Church: Henry II & Becket

L8: The Wars of the Roses (1455–85)

L4: Magna Carta (1215): Liberty or Grab?

L9: Capstone: How Powerful was a King?

L5: Village Life, Tithes & Doom Paintings

PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT TRACKER

Target Level: _____

CRITERIA	Emerging (1–2): Recalls isolated facts; basic descriptive narrative of kings/battles.	Emerging+ (3): Identifies causes & consequences with simple explanation.	Expected (4–5): Structured PEEL arguments; supports claims with specific medieval evidence.	Greater Depth (6–9): Analytical balance; nuanced historical judgements on power.
EFFORT	1 • Concern: Disengaged / incomplete work.	2 • Inconsistent: Requires repeated prompting.	3 • Satisfactory: Meets baseline expectations.	4 • Good / 5 • Exemplary: Proactive focus; voluntary Scholar's Edge extension.

LESSON / ENQUIRY TITLE	EFFORT (1–5)	LEVEL	TEACHER FORMATIVE FEEDBACK & NEXT STEPS
LESSON 1 Why did William of Normandy win the Battle of Hastings in 1066?			
LESSON 2 How did William the Conqueror establish and maintain control over England?			
LESSON 3 Why did the dispute between Henry II and Thomas Becket escalate into cathedral murder?			
LESSON 4 To what extent was Magna Carta (1215) a selfish baronial power grab rather than a charter of liberty?			
LESSON 5 How far did the Church and the manor court maintain total control over medieval peasants?			
LESSON 6 How far did the Black Death permanently destroy the medieval feudal system?			
LESSON 7 Was the Peasants' Revolt of 1381 a complete failure?			
LESSON 8 Why did England descend into civil war between the Houses of York and Lancaster?			
LESSON 9 "A medieval monarch had absolute power." How far do you agree? (1066–1485)			
FINAL UNIT LEVEL • TARGET OUTCOME:			

CURRICULUM ROADMAP & CHRONOLOGICAL SPINE

1066 – 1485

Trace the four-century struggle for authority in medieval England: from Norman military conquest to constitutional charters and peasant rebellion.

1066

The Norman Conquest & Battle of Hastings

Edward the Confessor dies; Harold Godwinson defeats Harald Hardrada at Stamford Bridge but falls to William of Normandy at Senlac Hill.

1069–1086

Castles, Terror & The Domesday Survey

Harrying of the North leaves 100,000 dead from famine; 500 Motte & Bailey castles built; 1086 Domesday Book audits English wealth.

1164–1170

Crown vs Church: The Becket Martyrdom

Henry II issues Constitutions of Clarendon to curtail Church courts; Thomas Becket murdered in Canterbury Cathedral (29 Dec 1170).

1215

Magna Carta Sealed at Runnymede

Rebellious barons force King John to seal the Great Charter, establishing for the first time that the monarch is subject to the rule of law.

1348–1350

The Black Death Devastates the Realm

Bubonic and pneumonic plague wipes out 40–50% of the population; catastrophic labour scarcity empowers surviving serfs.

1381

The Great Rising / Peasants' Revolt

Wat Tyler and preacher John Ball lead thousands of Kent and Essex peasants on London to demand the abolition of all serfdom and poll taxes.

1455–1485

The Wars of the Roses & Bosworth Field

Dynastic civil war between York and Lancaster; Richard III defeated and slain at Bosworth (1485); Henry VII founds the Tudor dynasty.



Hampshire & Meon Valley Local History Connection:

Our curriculum is rooted in our local Hampshire landscape: from **Portchester Castle** (where the Normans built a massive stone keep inside ancient Roman walls) and the Domesday survey of **Fareham, Titchfield, and Stubbington**, to **Bishop's Waltham Palace**, where the wealthy Bishops of Winchester extracted peasant tithes from the Meon Valley.

Turn overleaf to begin Lesson 1 (Pages 4–5 Facing Spread) →

L1: Why did William of Normandy win the Battle of Hastings in 1066?

CORE LEARNING OBJECTIVES:

- Explain the historical context, key protagonists, and competing perspectives of this enquiry.
- Deploy precise factual evidence to analyse cause, consequence, or historical significance.
- Formulate an independent, evaluative historical judgement supported by causal reasoning.

DO NOW: SPACED RETRIEVAL

Score: / 5

Q1 (Last)

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Q2 (Last)

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Q3 (2 Ago)

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Q4 (Unit)

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Q5 (Synoptic)

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CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Distinguish between elite, full-time warrior **housecarls** (armed with two-handed Danish axes) and the part-time peasant militia (**fyrð**):

TASK 4: TACTICAL ANALYSIS OF THE BATTLE OF HASTINGS (14 OCTOBER 1066)

Sketch the battlefield disposition on Senlac Hill below, then label the 4 decisive combat vectors:

- ① **Saxon Shield Wall** (interlocked linden shields atop ridge) • ② **Norman Heavy Cavalry** (stirrup-braced uphill charges) • ③ **The Feigned Retreat** (drawing the undisciplined fyrð downhill) • ④ **High-Angle Archery** (plunging fire blinding Harold)

Low-Floor Clue: Notice why cavalry could not break the shield wall on steep ground—why was the feigned retreat necessary to lure the Saxon fyrð down?

★ **Scholar's Edge:** Did William win through military genius, or did Harold lose through tactical recklessness and physical exhaustion after Stamford Bridge?

Enquiry: Why did William of Normandy win the Battle of Hastings in 1066?

INDEPENDENT ARGUMENT

1. NORMAN TACTICS

Explain how Norman cavalry charges, archer elevation, and especially the feigned retreat broke the Saxon shield wall atop Senlac Hill.

2. SAXON EXHAUSTION

Explain how Harold's army was depleted after marching 250 miles north to Stamford Bridge and 250 miles back south in under 3 weeks.

3. WEIGHING THE DECISIVE FACTOR

Give your final judgment: was William's military tactics and luck more decisive, or did Harold lose the battle through impatience and exhaustion?

Sentence Starters & Connectives: A primary reason for William's victory was... • In direct contrast, Harold's army was fatally weakened by... • Crucially, the turning point came when... • Weighing the evidence... • Ultimately, I judge that...

[P] Point: Clear direct answer to enquiry.

[E] Evidence: Specific medieval names, dates & facts.

[E] Explanation: Causal mechanism (why & how).

[L] Link: Direct evaluative conclusion.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal blue lines.

Teacher Assessment: Effort: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5] | Subject Knowledge: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4] | Disciplinary Analysis: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4]

PEEL Mastery: P E E L

L2: How did William the Conqueror establish and maintain control over England?

CORE LEARNING OBJECTIVES:

- Explain the historical context, key protagonists, and competing perspectives of this enquiry.
- Deploy precise factual evidence to analyse cause, consequence, or historical significance.
- Formulate an independent, evaluative historical judgement supported by causal reasoning.

DO NOW: SPACED RETRIEVAL

Score: / 5

Q1 (Last)

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Q2 (Last)

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Q3 (2 Ago)

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Q4 (Unit)

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Q5 (Synoptic)

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CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Write one historically accurate sentence connecting the rapid construction of **Motte and Bailey castles** to the fiscal control audited in the **Domesday Book**:

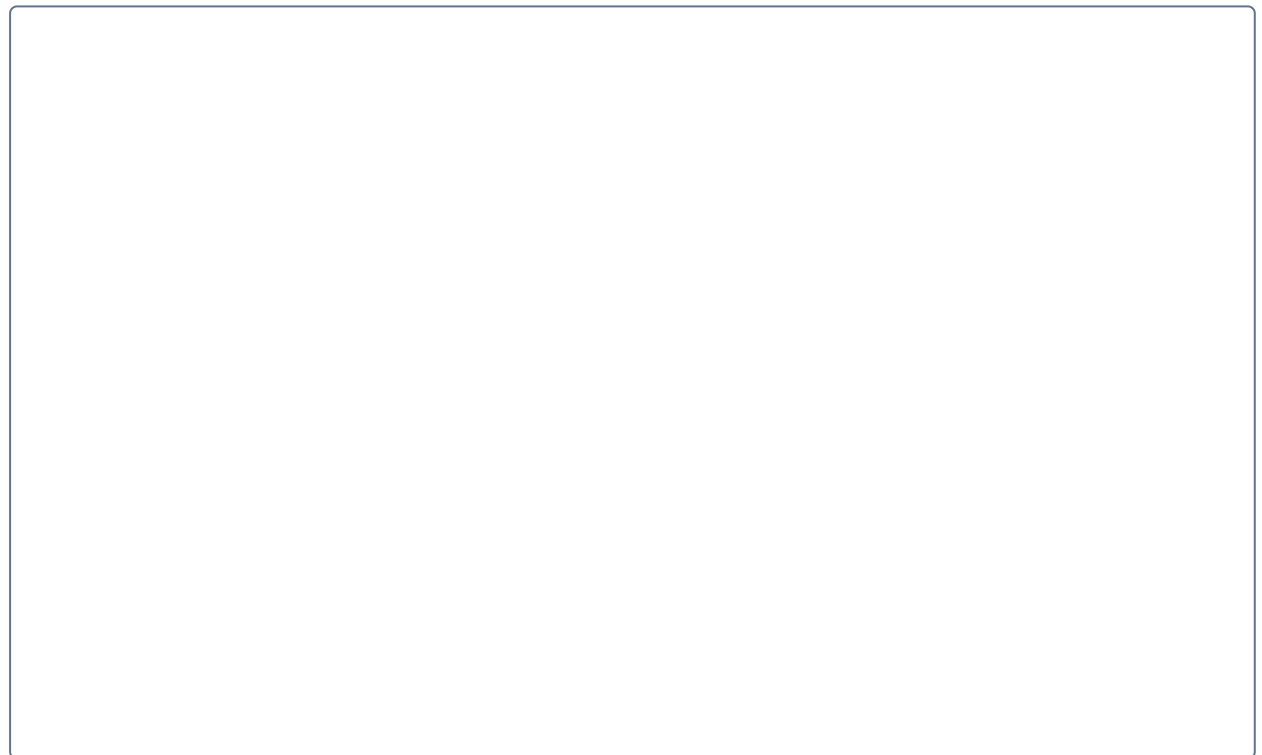
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TASK 4: DRAW & LABEL A NORMAN MOTTE & BAILEY CASTLE (1066–1087)

Sketch the castle structure below, labelling the 4 key engineering features that made resistance impossible:



- ① **Motte** (steep artificial earth mound up to 10m high) • ② **Keep / Tower** (wooden lookout tower with 360° sightlines) • ③ **Bailey** (enclosed courtyard for barracks, stables & forge) • ④ **Ditch & Palisade** (steep moat and sharpened oak perimeter wall)

Low-Floor Clue: A timber castle could be erected in 8–14 days by forced Saxon labour, giving 30 Norman knights total dominance over 5,000 peasants.

★ **Scholar's Edge:** How did local Hampshire castles like **Portchester Castle** (Norman keep built inside Roman walls) combine military force with bureaucratic tax collection?

Enquiry: How did William the Conqueror establish and maintain control over England?

INDEPENDENT ARGUMENT

1. MILITARY FORTIFICATION

Explain how building 500 Motte & Bailey castles allowed a tiny Norman elite (under 10,000 men) to garrison and police a hostile Saxon population of 2 million.

2. TERROR & SURVEILLANCE

Contrast the psychological devastation of the Harrying of the North (1069) against the bureaucratic surveillance of the 1086 Domesday Book survey.

3. OVERALL EVALUATION

Give your final judgment: which method was most essential for guaranteeing that the Norman Conquest became permanent rather than temporary?

Sentence Starters & Connectives: William immediately established physical control by... • Furthermore, he crushed northern rebellion through... • Administratively, the Domesday Book ensured... • Consequently, Norman rule was cemented because...

[P] Point: Clear direct answer to enquiry.

[E] Evidence: Specific medieval names, dates & facts.

[E] Explanation: Causal mechanism (why & how).

[L] Link: Direct evaluative conclusion.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 18 horizontal blue lines.

Teacher Assessment: Effort: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5] | Subject Knowledge: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4] | Disciplinary Analysis: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4]

PEEL Mastery: P E E L

L3: Why did the dispute between Henry II and Thomas Becket escalate into cathedral murder?

CORE LEARNING OBJECTIVES:

- Explain the historical context, key protagonists, and competing perspectives of this enquiry.
- Deploy precise factual evidence to analyse cause, consequence, or historical significance.
- Formulate an independent, evaluative historical judgement supported by causal reasoning.

DO NOW: SPACED RETRIEVAL

Score: / 5

Q1 (Last)

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Q2 (Last)

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Q3 (2 Ago)

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Q4 (Unit)

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Q5 (Synoptic)

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CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Complete the summary below using the terms *Constitutions of Clarendon* and *Benefit of Clergy*:

Henry II attempted to bring churchmen under royal criminal law through the [], but Becket defended the Church's immunity known as [].

Application: Explain why this legal dispute threatened Henry's royal authority:

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TASK 4: THE STRUGGLE FOR SUPREMACY: KING HENRY II VS. ARCHBISHOP THOMAS BECKET

Contrast the competing legal jurisdictions and political claims of the Crown against the Church below.

King Henry II (Royal Common Law)

- One single law for all Englishmen; end Church court leniency.
- Criminous clerks must be defrocked and hung by royal sheriffs.
- No appeals to the Pope in Rome without the King's explicit permission.
- Reassertion of royal taxes on wealthy episcopal Church estates.

👉 Synthesise their perspective in 2–3 sentences:

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Archbishop Thomas Becket (Canon Law)

- Church is sovereign; spiritual authority is higher than earthly kings.
- God's priests must never be judged or executed by secular men.
- Total obedience owed to Pope Alexander III in Rome above all oaths.
- Excommunication of royal barons and bishops who crowned Prince Henry.

👉 Synthesise their perspective in 2–3 sentences:

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Low-Floor Clue: Becket was Henry's closest drinking companion and Chancellor—why did his loyalties change so drastically when made Archbishop?

★ **Scholar's Edge:** Was Becket's death a genuine constitutional battle over national sovereignty, or a personal tragedy of stubborn pride?

Enquiry: Why did the dispute between Henry II and Thomas Becket escalate into cathedral murder?

INDEPENDENT ARGUMENT

1. THE LEGAL CLASH

Explain the Constitutions of Clarendon (1164) and Henry II's fury that Church courts protected 'criminous clerks' from royal hanging using 'benefit of clergy'.

2. ESCALATION & BETRAYAL

Explain Becket's unexpected transformation into an ascetic archbishop, his excommunication of royal bishops, and Henry's fatal outburst at Bures in France.

3. FINAL JUDGMENT

Give your final judgment: was Becket's murder caused by an unavoidable constitutional clash between Church and State, or two proud men refusing to compromise?

Sentence Starters & Connectives: The root cause of the conflict was... • Tension escalated dramatically when Becket... • In direct response, Henry II's fury resulted in... • Consequently, this led to... • Ultimately, I judge that...

[P] Point: Clear direct answer to enquiry.

[E] Evidence: Specific medieval names, dates & facts.

[E] Explanation: Causal mechanism (why & how).

[L] Link: Direct evaluative conclusion.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal blue lines.

Teacher Assessment: Effort: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5] | Subject Knowledge: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4] | Disciplinary Analysis: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4]

PEEL Mastery: P E E L

- Explain the historical context, key protagonists, and competing perspectives of this enquiry.
- Deploy precise factual evidence to analyse cause, consequence, or historical significance.
- Formulate an independent, evaluative historical judgement supported by causal reasoning.

Score: / 5

Q1 (Last)	Q2 (Last)	Q3 (2 Ago)	Q4 (Unit)	Q5 (Synoptic)
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Distinguish between 'shield money' paid instead of military service (**scutage**) and tyrannical rule without legal limit (**arbitrary power**):

1. Underline the exact phrase that places the King under the rule of law.
2. In the lines below, explain who actually counted as a "free man" in 1215, and why this shows the barons were protecting their own estates:

"No scutage nor aid shall be imposed on our kingdom, unless by common counsel of our kingdom... No free man shall be seized or imprisoned, or stripped of his rights or possessions, or outlawed or exiled... except by the lawful judgment of his equals or by the law of the land."

★ Scholar's Edge: Why did Victorian historians praise Magna Carta as the cradle of English liberty, while modern historians like J.C. Holt view it as a failed baronial pact?

L5: How far did the Church and the manor court maintain total control over medieval peasants?

CORE LEARNING OBJECTIVES:

- Explain the historical context, key protagonists, and competing perspectives of this enquiry.
- Deploy precise factual evidence to analyse cause, consequence, or historical significance.
- Formulate an independent, evaluative historical judgement supported by causal reasoning.

DO NOW: SPACED RETRIEVAL

Score: / 5

Q1 (Last)	Q2 (Last)	Q3 (2 Ago)	Q4 (Unit)	Q5 (Synoptic)

CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Write one historically accurate sentence connecting the collection of the Church **tithe** to the terror depicted in the medieval **Doom painting**:

TASK 4: DECONSTRUCTING THE MEDIEVAL PARISH CHURCH DOOM FRESCO

Analyse the contemporary Doom painting below, identifying how the visual layout reinforced obedience to the priest and the feudal lord:

① Christ in Majesty: Sitting on the rainbow of judgment above the chancel arch.	② Archangel Michael: Weighing souls on celestial scales; demons trying to tip the balance.
③ The Heavenly Citadel: St Peter welcoming the righteous, tithe-paying souls into the gates.	④ The Mouth of Hell: Gaping beast jaws (Leviathan) devouring dishonest millers and rebels.

Visual Forensic Interpretation: In 3–4 sentences, explain why this painting was more powerful than written law for an illiterate peasant congregation:

Low-Floor Clue: Notice who is being dragged into Hell—even bishops and greedy lords are shown, reminding serfs that everyone faces God’s court.

★ **Scholar’s Edge:** How did grand ecclesiastical palaces like **Bishop’s Waltham Palace** in Hampshire demonstrate the immense wealth bishops extracted from local peasant tithes?

Explain how tithes (10% of harvest), the Latin Mass, and terrifying Doom paintings enforced obedience through fear of eternal damnation.

Explain how forced labour (corvée), mill grinding monopolies, and death duties ('heriot') stripped villeins of wealth and personal freedom.

3. PEASANT AGENCY & SOLIDARITY

Evaluate whether peasants were powerless victims or able to exercise agency through village solidarity, brewing ale, and manorial court bargaining.

Sentence Starters & Connectives: The Church exercised profound psychological control through... • Concurrently, the lord's manor court policed daily labour by... • Despite this exploitation, villagers found agency when... • In summary, medieval peasant life was defined by...

[P] Point: Clear direct answer to enquiry.

[E] Evidence: Specific medieval names, dates & facts.

[E] Explanation: Causal mechanism (why & how).

[L] Link: Direct evaluative conclusion.

Teacher Assessment: Effort: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5] | Subject Knowledge: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4] |
Disciplinary Analysis: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4]

PEEL Mastery: P E
E L

L6: How far did the Black Death permanently destroy the medieval feudal system?

CORE LEARNING OBJECTIVES:

- Explain the historical context, key protagonists, and competing perspectives of this enquiry.
- Deploy precise factual evidence to analyse cause, consequence, or historical significance.
- Formulate an independent, evaluative historical judgement supported by causal reasoning.

DO NOW: SPACED RETRIEVAL

Score: / 5

Q1 (Last)

Q2 (Last)

Q3 (2 Ago)

Q4 (Unit)

Q5 (Synoptic)

CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Complete the summary below using the terms *Statute of Labourers* and *Serfdom*:

When the acute labour shortage enabled peasants to demand double wages, Parliament attempted to protect [] by passing the repressive 1351 [].

Application: Explain why landlords secretly broke this law and paid higher wages anyway:

TASK 4: THE SOCIO-ECONOMIC DOMINO CHAIN OF THE BLACK DEATH (1348–1351)

Track the transformation of England from pandemic devastation to peasant empowerment below:

1. Mortality Shock (1348–49)

Plague kills 40–50% of the population; crops rot in untended fields across Hampshire.

2. Labour Scarcity (1350)

Surviving villeins realise their labour is invaluable; demand wages in silver pennies.

3. Baronial Panic (1351)

Parliament passes the Statute of Labourers, freezing wages at 1346 rates on pain of prison.

4. Feudal Collapse (1360s+)

Landlords compete for workers by secretly paying high wages; serfs walk off manors.

Causal Analysis: In 3–4 sentences, explain why the 1351 Statute of Labourers failed to stop peasants demanding higher wages and winning their freedom:

★ **Scholar's Edge:** Why do modern economic historians call the generation after the Black Death the "Golden Age of the English Peasantry"?

Explain the catastrophic demographic collapse (over 40% mortality), untended fields, abandoned villages, and total breakdown of farming in 1348–49.

Explain how severe labour scarcity gave surviving serfs immense bargaining power to demand high cash wages and flee manors for better pay.

3. COLLAPSE OF SERFDOM

Give your judgment: did the plague instantly destroy feudalism, or did it accelerate economic changes that took another century to finish?

Sentence Starters & Connectives: The initial devastation of the Black Death caused... • Crucially, this created an acute labour shortage which... • Although the Crown attempted to freeze wages with the 1351 Statute of Labourers... • Consequently, the balance of power shifted because... • Ultimately, I judge that...

[P] Point: Clear direct answer to enquiry.

[E] Evidence: Specific medieval names, dates & facts.

[E] Explanation: Causal mechanism (why & how).

[L] Link: Direct evaluative conclusion.

Teacher Assessment: Effort: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5] | Subject Knowledge: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4] |
Disciplinary Analysis: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4]

PEEL Mastery: P E
E L

L7: Was the Peasants' Revolt of 1381 a complete failure?

CORE LEARNING OBJECTIVES:

- Explain the historical context, key protagonists, and competing perspectives of this enquiry.
- Deploy precise factual evidence to analyse cause, consequence, or historical significance.
- Formulate an independent, evaluative historical judgement supported by causal reasoning.

DO NOW: SPACED RETRIEVAL

Score: / 5

Q1 (Last)

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Q2 (Last)

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Q3 (2 Ago)

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Q4 (Unit)

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Q5 (Synoptic)

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CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Distinguish between an unfair flat-rate head tax (**Poll Tax**) and the unfree feudal condition of serfdom (**villeinage**):

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TASK 4: THE BALANCE SHEET OF 1381: REVOLUTIONARY DEMANDS VS. ROYAL RETRIBUTION

Contrast the radical demands made at Mile End and Smithfield against the brutal retribution of King Richard II.

The Rebel Demands (Wat Tyler & John Ball)

- Complete abolition of serfdom, villeinage, and bonded labour.
- Flat land rent of 4 pence per acre; freedom to work anywhere.
- Confiscation and redistribution of wealthy Church bishop estates.
- Equality before the law: "When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?"

👉 Synthesise their perspective in 2–3 sentences:

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The Crown's Retribution (Richard II & Barons)

- Wat Tyler butchered at Smithfield by Mayor Walworth and royal knights.
- Richard II's betrayal: "Villeins you are, and villeins you shall remain."
- Royal charters of freedom torn up and officially annulled by Parliament.
- Over 1,500 rebels executed without jury trial in Kent, Essex, and London.

👉 Synthesise their perspective in 2–3 sentences:

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Low-Floor Clue: Did the 14-year-old Richard II ever intend to keep the promises he made when surrounded by 20,000 angry peasants?

★ **Scholar's Edge:** *Did the Peasants' Revolt fail militarily in June 1381, but succeed politically by terrifying the aristocracy out of ever taxing peasants again?*

Enquiry: Was the Peasants' Revolt of 1381 a complete failure? INDEPENDENT ARGUMENT

1. THE SHORT-TERM FAILURE

Explain the short-term crushing: Wat Tyler murdered at Smithfield, Richard II's treachery, revocation of charters, and 1,500 executions.

2. THE LONG-TERM SUCCESS

Explain the long-term triumph: no Poll Tax levied again for 600 years, landlords stopped enforcing villeinage, and serfdom died within 50 years.

3. FINAL EVALUATIVE VERDICT

Give your final judgment: was the 1381 revolt a tragic failure of leadership, or a pivotal historical turning point towards English liberty?

Sentence Starters & Connectives: In the immediate aftermath, the revolt appeared to be a total failure because... • However, from a long-term perspective, the rebels achieved their core goals because... • The ruling class was profoundly terrified, resulting in... • Ultimately, I conclude that...

[P] Point: Clear direct answer to enquiry.

[E] Evidence: Specific medieval names, dates & facts.

[E] Explanation: Causal mechanism (why & how).

[L] Link: Direct evaluative conclusion.

Handwriting practice lines for the independent argument.

Teacher Assessment: Effort: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5] | Subject Knowledge: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4] | Disciplinary Analysis: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4]

PEEL Mastery: P E E L

L8: Why did England descend into civil war between the Houses of York and Lancaster?

CORE LEARNING OBJECTIVES:

- Explain the historical context, key protagonists, and competing perspectives of this enquiry.
- Deploy precise factual evidence to analyse cause, consequence, or historical significance.
- Formulate an independent, evaluative historical judgement supported by causal reasoning.

DO NOW: SPACED RETRIEVAL

Score: / 5

Q1 (Last)

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Q2 (Last)

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Q3 (2 Ago)

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Q4 (Unit)

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Q5 (Synoptic)

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CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Write one analytical sentence connecting **bastard feudalism** (contracts for money) to the private noble armies of armed **liveried retainers**:

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TASK 4: THE DYNASTIC CRUCIBLE: THE RED ROSE OF LANCASTER VS. THE WHITE ROSE OF YORK

Balance the rival claims, military commanders, and strategic vulnerabilities of both warring houses below.

The House of Lancaster (The Red Rose)

- King Henry VI: Pious but completely incompetent; suffered mental breakdowns.
- Queen Margaret of Anjou: Fierce protector of Prince Edward; hated York.
- Catastrophic loss of all English territory in France (except Calais) by 1453.
- Deep financial bankruptcy and reliance on corrupt court favorites (Somerset).

👉 Synthesise their perspective in 2–3 sentences:

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The House of York (The White Rose)

- Richard Duke of York: Wealthy, capable general with a stronger bloodline claim.
- Edward IV: Charismatic, towering warrior who won the throne at Towton (1461).
- Richard Neville, Earl of Warwick: "The Kingmaker", wealthiest noble in England.
- Strong military backing from London merchants and southern landowners.

👉 Synthesise their perspective in 2–3 sentences:

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Low-Floor Clue: In "bastard feudalism", knights wore their lord's badge (e.g. Warwick's Bear and Ragged Staff) rather than the King's royal coat of arms.

★ **Scholar's Edge:** Was the Wars of the Roses an inevitable war between rival bloodlines, or an artificial conflict fought purely for land by 60 noble families?

Enquiry: Why did England descend into civil war between the Houses of York and Lancaster?

INDEPENDENT ARGUMENT

1. MONARCHICAL WEAKNESS

Explain how King Henry VI's mental catatonia, military humiliation in the Hundred Years War, and favoritism towards Somerset created a power vacuum.

2. BASTARD FEUDALISM & PRIVATE ARMIES

Explain how overmighty nobles with private armies of liveried retainers fought each other for wealth, influence, and regional supremacy.

3. FINAL JUDGMENT

Give your final judgment: was the civil war caused primarily by the personal incompetence of Henry VI, or by the structural flaws of late-medieval feudalism?

Sentence Starters & Connectives: The primary catalyst for civil war was the weakness of Henry VI, who... • This crisis was intensified by 'bastard feudalism', which meant... • Bloodshed erupted into full civil war when... • Overall, royal authority collapsed because...

[P] Point: Clear direct answer to enquiry.

[E] Evidence: Specific medieval names, dates & facts.

[E] Explanation: Causal mechanism (why & how).

[L] Link: Direct evaluative conclusion.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal blue lines.

Teacher Assessment: Effort: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5] | Subject Knowledge: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4] | Disciplinary Analysis: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4]

PEEL Mastery: P E E L

L9: “A medieval monarch had absolute power.” How far do you agree? (1066–1485)

CORE LEARNING OBJECTIVES:

- Explain the historical context, key protagonists, and competing perspectives of this enquiry.
- Deploy precise factual evidence to analyse cause, consequence, or historical significance.
- Formulate an independent, evaluative historical judgement supported by causal reasoning.

DO NOW: SPACED RETRIEVAL

Score: / 5

Q1 (Last)

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Q2 (Last)

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Q3 (2 Ago)

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Q4 (Unit)

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Q5 (Synoptic)

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CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Distinguish between unrestricted rule by royal command (**absolute monarchy**) and rule bounded by legal charters like Magna Carta (**limited monarchy**):

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TASK 4: THE ROYAL POWER SPECTRUM: FOUR CHECKS ON MEDIEVAL ENGLISH KINGS (1066–1485)

Audit the 4 major forces that successfully checked and limited royal authority across the medieval centuries:

① The Barons (Aristocracy)

Magna Carta (1215) restricted arbitrary taxation; Simon de Montfort's Parliament (1265); Wars of the Roses overthrew Henry VI & Richard III.

② The Catholic Church

Becket resisted royal courts (1170); Pope Innocent III placed England under Interdict (1208); Church owned 25% of all English land.

③ The Peasantry & Economy

Black Death labour scarcity (1348) broke feudal bondage; 1381 Peasants' Revolt marched on London and executed the Archbishop.

④ Succession & Warfare

William won by force at Hastings (1066); Henry VII took the crown by combat at Bosworth (1485); weak kings were deposed (Edward II, Richard II).

Synoptic Synthesis: In 3–4 sentences, explain which of these four checks was the most dangerous threat to a medieval monarch's throne:

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★ **Scholar's Edge:** Did medieval kings rule through divine authority and the rule of law, or through the sheer physical threat of castles, swords, and executions?

Enquiry: “A medieval monarch had absolute power.” How far do you agree? (1066–1485)

INDEPENDENT ARGUMENT

1. THE CASE FOR ABSOLUTE POWER

Explain the immense authority of kings: summit of the feudal pyramid, ownership of all land, royal courts, military command, and divine legitimacy.

2. THE REALITY OF CHECKS & REBELLION

Explain the checks on kingship: baronial revolts (1215 Magna Carta), Church power (1170 Becket), peasant uprisings (1381), and dynastic overthrow (1485).

3. YOUR SYNOPTIC JUDGMENT

Formulate your sustained thesis: was medieval royal power absolute, or was it always fragile and dependent on keeping the barons and Church satisfied?

Sentence Starters & Connectives: Proponents of royal supremacy argue that medieval monarchs held absolute power because... • However, this power was strictly conditional, repeatedly limited by... • Looking across the entire period from 1066 to 1485... • In conclusion, medieval kings were not absolute rulers because...

[P] Point: Clear direct answer to enquiry.

[E] Evidence: Specific medieval names, dates & facts.

[E] Explanation: Causal mechanism (why & how).

[L] Link: Direct evaluative conclusion.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal blue lines.

Teacher Assessment: Effort: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5] | Subject Knowledge: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4] | Disciplinary Analysis: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4]

PEEL Mastery: P E E L

MEDIEVAL DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY MASTERY VAULT

KEY CONCEPTS

Mastery of these high-yield disciplinary and substantive concepts is essential for achieving Grade 6–9 in KS3 History extended writing:

Feudal System (Hierarchy):

Social pyramid where King granted land (fiefs) to tenants-in-chief (barons/bishops) in return for military service; barons granted land to knights; unfree peasants (villeins) farmed the land.

Domesday Book (1086):

Great survey ordered by William I recording every landholding, plough, mill, and pig in England to maximise royal tax revenue and prevent baronial tax evasion.

Benefit of Clergy & Canon Law:

The legal privilege whereby churchmen accused of crime were tried only in lenient Church courts governed by papal canon law, escaping royal execution.

Magna Carta (Rule of Law):

The 1215 charter forcing King John to concede that royal power is not absolute and that even the monarch is bound by the established law of the land.

Tithe & Doom Paintings:

A mandatory 10% tax paid to the Church; reinforced by terrifying murals above the chancel arch depicting sinners pitched into the mouth of Hell.

Statute of Labourers (1351):

Repressive parliamentary law attempting to freeze peasant wages at pre-plague rates; completely failed due to economic laws of supply and demand.

Poll Tax & The Great Rising:

Regressive flat tax of 12 groats (1 shilling) per person, provoking the 1381 rebellion under Wat Tyler demanding total abolition of serfdom.

Bastard Feudalism:

Late-medieval practice where wealthy lords paid cash retainers to maintain private armies wearing their livery badges, sparking the Wars of the Roses.

END OF UNIT REFLECTION & PUPIL VOICE

PUPIL VOICE

Unit: Medieval England & The Struggle for Power • Year 7 History

1. WHAT WENT WELL (WWW)

Key Strengths & Insights

Which medieval enquiry, historical source, or extended writing skill did you find most compelling or master most successfully?

2. EVEN BETTER IF (EBI)

Areas for Growth

Which concept (e.g. feudal contracts, benefit of clergy, or weighing conflicting historical interpretations) did you find most challenging?

TEACHER FORMATIVE COACHING & NEXT STEPS

Completed post-assessment

Teacher feedback confirming unit mastery, validating reflection, and setting next unit targets:

DEPARTMENTAL MARKING POLICY & CODE

POLICY

Meoncross School History Department Standard

CORRECTION & PROOFREADING SYMBOLS:

Sp: Spelling error

P: Punctuation missing

//: New paragraph needed

^: Word omitted

THE KS3 EXTENDED WRITING FORMULA (PEEL):

[P] Point: Open with a punchy topic sentence directly answering the enquiry factor.

[E] Explanation: Unpack the causal mechanism using analytical connectives (*Consequently, Pivotal*).

[E] Evidence: Deploy 2+ precise historical facts (exact dates, named individuals, statistics).

[L] Link: Evaluate relative significance and link directly back to the overarching inquiry.

EFFORT GRADE DESCRIPTORS (1–5 SCALE):

- **5 • Exemplary:** Proactive scholarship, voluntary Scholar's Edge extension, impeccable presentation.
- **4 • Good:** Consistent focus, fully completed tasks, accurate deployment of historical vocabulary.
- **3 • Satisfactory:** Baseline requirements met; core tasks completed with standard effort.
- **2 • Inconsistent / 1 • Concern:** Unfinished work, lack of historical detail, intervention required.